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To cite this article: Andrew Moreo, Lisa Cain, Imran Rahman & Yangsu Chen (2019) How emotional displays and service quality impact satisfaction and loyalty: A gendered look, *Journal of Foodservice Business Research*, 22:6, 563-581, DOI: [10.1080/15378020.2019.1663105](https://doi.org/10.1080/15378020.2019.1663105)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/15378020.2019.1663105>



Published online: 07 Sep 2019.



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How emotional displays and service quality impact satisfaction and loyalty: A gendered look

Andrew Moreo^a, Lisa Cain^a, Imran Rahman^b and Yangsu Chen^c

^aChaplin School of Hospitality & Tourism Management, Florida International University, North Miami, FL, USA;

^bDepartment of Nutrition, Dietetics, & Hospitality Management College of Human Sciences, Auburn University, Auburn, AL, USA; ^cAmazon, Seattle, WA, USA

ABSTRACT

Success in the restaurant industry is, in part, determined by boundary spanning service providers' ability to manage their emotions with the goal of providing excellent service while simultaneously authentically displaying the proper emotions to connect with the guest. How men and women respond to these displays of emotion is of interest, as previous scholars have demonstrated perceptions and reactions to service delivery differ across genders. This study utilized a between subject quasi-experimental design manipulating each one of the independent variables (gender, emotional labor, and service quality) in a dichotomous fashion for each scenario. The dependent variables measured were satisfaction and loyalty. The results indicated that women are more receptive to deep acting than are their male counterparts, and are thus, more likely to be loyal to an organization if deep acting is employed. How to encourage deep acting among foodservice providers is discussed.

KEYWORDS

Emotional labor; gender; surface acting; deep acting; loyalty; satisfaction

Introduction

Hochschild (1983) described the regulation of feelings and expressions, known as emotional labor. Since its initial discussion, emotional labor has become one of the essential attributes of any service job. Service providers need to display emotions that they do not necessarily feel during the service encounter with the customer. This implies using acting to minimize the discomfort that might accompany the discrepancy between the felt and demonstrated emotional states. Service providers may choose between surface acting and deep acting (Hochschild, 1983). Surface acting is where one's inner emotions do not align with the way in which that individual is portraying their emotions externally. For example, if a server is angry, but must 'wear a smile,' he is surface acting. Conversely, deep acting is where one's inner emotions have been aligned with one's outward countenance. The impact of emotional labor on frontline service providers and its necessity in the workplace, have been the subject of much research. While there are also studies that examine the service interaction through the customers' view of emotional labor, many of these utilized retail (e.g. Tang, Seal, Naumann, & Miguel, 2013), lodging (e.g. Mattila, 2000), or tourism (e.g. Van Dijk, Smith, & Cooper, 2011) as the research setting. While there are

CONTACT Andrew Moreo  Amoreo@fiu.edu Chaplin School of Hospitality & Tourism Management, Florida International University, 3000 Northeast 151st Street, North Miami, FL 33181, USA

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a few studies investigating the relationship in the restaurant industry, these are limited (Groth, Hennig-Thurau, & Walsh, 2009).

Research has demonstrated that positive emotional displays by service providers are related to higher levels of service evaluations by customers as well as their increased loyalty (Barger & Grandey, 2006). Furthermore, the authenticity of such displays increases customer satisfaction (Hennig-Thurau, Groth, Paul, & Gremler, 2006). Thus, emotional labor is becoming an important element in the customer service evaluation – customer satisfaction – customer loyalty chain.

Additionally, service quality has been demonstrated to be one of the most important factors that impacts customers' loyalty (Groth et al., 2009). SERVQUAL, one of the most widely used tools for measuring service quality, is comprised of five dimensions: (1) tangibles; (2) reliability; (3) responsiveness; (4) assurance; and (5) empathy, (Parasuraman, Zeithaml, & Berry, 1988), complementing the measurement of authenticity through emotional labor.

As perceptions of emotions are subjective in nature, the personal characteristics (e.g. gender, age, race, etc.) of the customer play a significant role in the service evaluation process, as well as in the outcomes – satisfaction and loyalty. Examining gender specifically, there are biological factors, cultural influences, and social and societal expectations that may innately present themselves through this personal characteristic (Chaplin, 2015). For example, it has been posited that females are more adept at the dissemination and reception of nonverbal cues (Briton & Hall, 1995), and are better able to identify facial expressions correctly (Collignon et al., 2010). In service encounters women derive more value from the affective component of service, while for men the cognitive component is more important (Chiu & Wu, 2002). Because all servers experience and demonstrate emotions during the service encounter, some of which may not be aligned, it is important to understand whether and how surface acting versus deep acting impacts the customer experience, and whether this differs across genders. This study focused on determining how emotional labor and service quality are related to customer satisfaction and customer loyalty depending on the customer's gender. The following research questions were addressed:

- (1) How does emotional labor influence customer satisfaction and loyalty in the context of a restaurant?
- (2) How does customer gender effect satisfaction under variable service and emotional labor conditions?
- (3) How does customer gender effect loyalty under variable service and emotional labor conditions?

The current literature is lacking in significant research from a customer perspective on the perception of the use of varying strategies of emotional labor in the restaurant industry (Hennig-Thurau et al., 2006). Moreover, the differences between the genders in this perception has received even less attention. Not only is there a gap in the literature, but this avenue of research provides valuable insight for the industry as it can inform management regarding the importance (or lack of importance) in allocating resources for specific emotional labor training for frontline employees, based on the primary customer demographic of the operation.

Literature review

Emotional labor

Overview of emotional labor concepts

The term *emotional labor* was first coined by Hochschild in 1983 and was defined as “the management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display” (p. 7). Service with a smile is a part of the uniform of many hospitality service providers, but the incongruity between what the service provider feels and what they need to display may result in cognitive dissonance. Festinger (1962) introduced the theory of cognitive dissonance, which refers to the discomfort experienced when a person’s actual emotion does not coincide with the expression of emotion, and Hochschild elaborated on it in through the concept of emotional labor (1983).

Hochschild (1983) first suggested that service providers performing emotional labor could implement two strategies: *surface acting* and *deep acting*. Surface acting implies that a service provider simply displays the appropriate emotion without internalizing it. Deep acting, on the other hand, is characterized by aligning one’s internal feelings with the external display of emotions portrayed during the service encounter.

Later, researchers moved the emphasis from the service provider’s feelings while performing emotional labor to “behavioral expectations about which emotions ought to be expressed and which ought to be hidden” (Rafaeli & Sutton, 1989, p. 8). Grandey (2000) presented a more complete picture of emotional labor by synthesizing the previous concepts and defining emotional labor as “the process of regulating both feelings and expressions for the organizational goals” (p.97).

Emotional labor and the customer

With most of the research on emotional labor being focused on the impact that it has on service providers, there is a relative scarcity of research concerning the impact of emotional labor on the consumer. Research on emotional behavioral displays of service providers demonstrated that the service provider’s positive facial expressions (e.g. smiling) were correlated to customers reporting higher levels of service quality and greater likelihood of re-patronizing the establishment (Barger & Grandey, 2006; Mattila & Enz, 2002).

Not just the emotional display itself but also the quality of this emotional display has been evaluated. The results demonstrated that deep acting is perceived as more authentic than surface acting due to the discernment that the emotions displayed are more genuine (Groth, Hennig-Thurau, & Wang, 2013). A study by Hennig-Thurau et al. (2006) clearly demonstrated a significant positive correlation between the authenticity of the smiles and customers’ emotional state.

Groth et al. (2009) found that the customers evaluated the service encounter more positively when they perceived the service as deep acting. On the contrary, perception of the service provider to be surface acting resulted in a negative opinion of the interaction with this negative reaction being stronger than the positive reaction to deep acting.

Grandey, Fisk, Mattila, Jansen, and Sideman (2005) identified that overall satisfaction was positively impacted by the perceived authenticity of the hotel front desk agent, but only when service was provided well. Thus, authenticity can be regarded as a characteristic that enhances the quality of the encounter. Consistent with other studies, Chi, Grandey,

Diamond, and Krimmel (2011) found that service providers employing deep acting exceeded the expectations of their customers and were rewarded with higher levels of tips.

Service quality, satisfaction, and loyalty

Service quality and satisfaction were named among the most important factors that impact customers' loyalty (Groth et al., 2009). SERVQUAL, developed by Parasuraman et al. (1988), is one of the most widely used tools for measuring service quality. The authors suggested that service quality is a function of the differences between the customer's expectations and their perceptions of the service. Thus, SERVQUAL is used to measure this gap along five dimensions: (1) tangibles – appearance of facilities, equipment, and look of the service provider; (2) reliability – ability of the providers to deliver the promised service; (3) responsiveness – willingness and ability of the providers to be prompt in their service delivery; (4) assurance – conveyance of trust and confidence; and (5) empathy – caring and individualized attention. Even though objective measurement of service quality is difficult to perform, it is significant because of the observed correlation between quality of service and customer satisfaction (Cronin & Taylor, 1992), as well as customer loyalty (Groth et al., 2009).

The concepts of customer satisfaction stem mainly from the works of Lewin (1938) and Oliver (1980) where expectancy-disconfirmation theory was developed. This theory is based on the cognitive process of confirmation of expectation when customers compare perceived performance with their pre-consumption expectation and evaluate their level of satisfaction accordingly. Thus, performance that has exceeded the expectations results in the positive disconfirmation and consequently customer satisfaction, while the experience that has been below the expectations leads to the negative disconfirmation and hence dissatisfied customer. Research has demonstrated an integral link between customer satisfaction and loyalty (Ladhari, Brun, & Morales, 2008).

Loyalty is commonly understood as a non-random behavioral response (repeat purchase of a product or service), expressed over time, in respect to a particular brand out of a set of alternative brands (Jacoby & Kyner, 1973). It is a function of psychological processes that results in repeat purchase behavior and the consumer's desire to maintain a relationship (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). However, loyalty could be characterized not only by re-purchase intentions, but also by positive word-of-mouth or willingness to pay more for a service (Jones, Taylor, & Bansal, 2008; Ladhari et al., 2008). Thus, purchase frequency and word-of mouth recommendations are often used to measure customer loyalty (Evanschitzky et al., 2012).

Gender differences

Gender differences in various aspects of human personality, reflected in the metaphor that men are from Mars and women are from Venus (Gray, 1992), have been researched for many years. For example, a stereotypical belief is that women are more emotional than are their male counterparts (Timmers, Fischer, & Manstead, 2003). There are three main theoretical approaches through which the variability in emotional behavior between males and females are explained: biological/genetic, social developmental, and social constructionist.

Biological theories highlight the attributes that are inherent to males or females, such as genes, hormones or functional brain anatomy which differ across gender. For example, studies of differences across the sexes in the regions of the brain involved in emotional manifestation, discernment, and experience demonstrate that males have more lateralization of brain function than females (Russo, Persegani, Papeschi, Nicolini, & Trimarchi, 2000). In addition, from an anatomical perspective, temporal cortex asymmetry is more prevalent in men (Good et al., 2001), while specific parts of the limbic system in women have a higher volume of gray-matter (Good et al. 2001) which leads to gender differences in emotion processing.

Social-developmental theories suggest that children learn behaviors consistent to their gender roles over time through cognitive learning, socialization, and experience (Liben & Bigler, 2002). *Social learning theories* suggest that children are encouraged to behave according to their gender roles either through explicit teaching, modeling, or through indirect promotion of certain behaviors (Bandura, 1969).

The third approach to gender differences in emotions is represented by *social constructionist theories*, which are focused on the idea of continuous social interaction between the person and their environment (Shields, 2002).

Recently the *bio-psycho-social developmental model*, which unites all three approaches, has been proposed and elaborated upon. Chaplin (2015) posited that differences in emotions across genders reveal themselves innately through a combination of biological factors, cultural influences, and social and societal expectations.

Gender and emotion processing

Nonverbal judgment accuracy

Briton and Hall (1995) found that gender differences in cognitive functions prompted respondents to assume that gender differences exist when processing information about emotions. It was revealed that women are viewed as more skilled at the dissemination and reception of nonverbal messages. Meta-analyses identified that there was a statistically significant, yet medium-sized difference in the ability to decode nonverbal signals of emotion, consisting of vocal prosody, postures, gestures, and facial expressions. Women have consistently outperformed men at both identifying and interpreting nonverbal cues (Hall, 1978, 1984).

Processing of emotional facial expressions

Facial expression recognition with corresponding gender differences has been one of the most studied components of nonverbal affective information processing. Previous studies suggest that the ability to recognize emotion in facial expressions is different between men and women and women were found to be more adept at identifying facial emotion (Collignon et al., 2010; Guillem & Mogg, 2005; Montagne, Kessels, Frigerio, de Haan, & Perrett, 2005; Thayer & Johnsen, 2000). Study results have also demonstrated that women possess an advantage in emotion recognition only for certain sets of emotions (Goos & Silverman, 2002).

Gender, service quality, emotion, satisfaction, and loyalty

Evaluation of the service encounter is considered to be more difficult than the evaluation of the purchase of a product (Iacobucci & Ostrom, 1993) because of the two-dimensional

interaction between the guest and the service provider (Berry, 1983). In a study examining two types of service provision (waiters and attorneys), researchers found that attitudes concerning 'good' core performance were often uniform across the genders. However, women valued the relationship component significantly more than men, who were significantly more concerned with the core performance (Iacobucci & Ostrom, 1993). Chiu and Wu (2002) found that when examining various service encounters (banking, education, laundry, and passenger transportation) women were significantly more concerned with the affective dimension as opposed to the cognitive dimension. These findings were further supported by a study which also found that women were more concerned with the interpersonal interaction in their service encounter with airlines, than were men (Anderson, Pearo, & Widener, 2008).

The influence of different socio-demographic characteristics, including gender, on customers' perception of services in the hospitality industry has also been researched (Christia & Ard, 2016). Thus, in relatively low-involvement environment of fast-food restaurants female customers demonstrated significantly higher levels of service quality expectations than male customers in such dimensions of fast food service as tangibles, reliability, responsiveness, and empathy. Furthermore, the results showed that women ranked both the affective and cognitive components of service quality higher than did men (Yelkur & Chakrabarty, 2006). In buffet restaurants, the impact of service quality on overall customer satisfaction was higher for women than for men (Ramanathan, Di, & Ramanathan, 2016). Research on ethnic restaurants (Ma, Qu, & Njite, 2011) and fine-dining restaurants identified that staff services had a greater impact on customer satisfaction and restaurant image among female customers than male customers (Ma, Qu, & Eliwa, 2014).

Mattila, Grandey, and Fisk (2003) conducted a study on the perceptions of service quality provided by a hotel's front desk agent in both success and failure conditions moderated by positive (smile, crinkles around the eyes) or negative (no smile, signs of irritation) affective displays. It was found that with positive affective displays in a no-fail situation there was no difference between men and women in evaluation of their satisfaction, while with negative affective displays women rated their satisfaction significantly lower than men. Furthermore, in the failed service encounter a negative affective display didn't accentuate women's dissatisfaction, while men assessed the experience much lower in the same situation. This can be accounted for in that the service provider in this study was a female, and so these results were expected (Mattila et al., 2003).

When an additional variable, authenticity of positive display (Duchenne smile, deep acting vs. surface acting), was used in research on customer perception of service quality during simulated hotel check-in encounter and real restaurant context it was found that it had a direct effect on customer satisfaction. When gender was controlled it demonstrated a small significant effect on evaluation of friendliness of the service provider but did not have any significant effect on overall encounter satisfaction (Grandey et al., 2005).

It has been suggested that men and women differ in their independence or interdependence in their daily lives, where women tend to display higher levels of interdependence than do men (Cross & Madson, 1997; Markus & Kitayama, 1991). This can manifest in a tendency for women to be more loyal than men, and thus seek more stable and established relationships both interpersonally and with organizations (Cross & Madson, 1997; Melnyk, Van Osselaer, & Bijmolt, 2009). This also crosses into the consumer realm

as it has been demonstrated that women tend to be more loyal to a service provider (Cross & Madson, 1997; Markus & Kitayama, 1991). Social role theory (Archer, 1996; Eagly, 1987) also supports this idea in that it suggests men are more likely to engage in risky behavior than are women. As changing service providers can be seen as a risk, it has been suggested that women exhibit higher levels of loyalty even with a change in satisfaction (Walsh, Evanschitzky, & Wunderlich, 2008).

Han and Ryu (2009) found that the relationship between satisfaction and revisit intention was significantly moderated by gender in an upscale restaurant setting. Jin, Line, and Goh (2013) also found that gender moderated the relationship between relationship quality and behavioral loyalty as well as the relationship between attitudinal loyalty and behavioral loyalty in full-service restaurant customers. Shapoval, Murphy, and Severt (2018) also found that gender moderated the relationship between satisfaction and loyalty among Millennials in a “Green Restaurant”.

The totality of the preceding literature on service quality, emotional perceptions, authenticity, gender, satisfaction, and loyalty demonstrates that there is a relationship among these constructs. The majority of the literature supports the notion that women tend to be more concerned with the emotional side of the service encounter, yet this has not been a universal result. The literature being far from conclusive indicates the need for further investigation.

Customers' positive or negative evaluation of their service encounters can be, in part, due to the authenticity of the service provider as determined by their choice of emotional labor strategy (surface or deep acting) (Groth et al., 2009). It is not only the appraisal of service quality that is impacted, but satisfaction, and loyalty as well (Cronin & Taylor, 1992; Groth et al., 2009; Ladhari et al., 2008). The subjective nature of service quality, satisfaction, and loyalty forces those constructs to be evaluated through the lens of personal characteristics (e.g. gender), thus requiring researchers to consider the impact of those personal characteristics on the outcomes. Previous research has begun to explore the effect of deep acting and surface acting on satisfaction and loyalty (Moreo, Woods, Sammons, & Bergman, 2018).

The current study sought to examine whether or not gender played a role in the indication of consumer satisfaction and loyalty under differing service quality and emotional display conditions. Based on the extensive literature review in this section, the following hypotheses were proposed:

H1: Emotional labor significantly influences customer satisfaction such that when emotional labor changes from deep-acting to surface-acting, customer satisfaction decreases.

H2: Emotional labor significantly influences customer loyalty such that when emotional labor changes from deep-acting to surface-acting, customer loyalty decreases.

H3: When service quality is high, females demonstrate a significantly higher degree of satisfaction than males and vice versa.

H4: When service quality is high, females demonstrate a significantly higher degree of loyalty than males and vice versa.

H5: When emotional labor is deep-acting, females demonstrate significantly higher satisfaction than males; such a significant effect is not found when emotional labor is surface-acting.

H6: When emotional labor is deep-acting, females demonstrate significantly higher loyalty than males; such a significant effect is not found when emotional labor is surface-acting.

Methodology

Design

Three dichotomous variables (gender, emotional labor and service quality) were the independent variables in this between-subjects quasi-experimental design. Gender (male, female), emotional labor (surface acting, deep acting), and service quality (low quality, high quality) comprised the cells of the 2x2x2 matrix. The study utilized four scenarios to gauge the impact of these independent variables (1) surface acting, low quality; (2) surface acting, high quality; (3) deep acting, low quality; (4) deep acting, high quality. The gender of the respondent was used to create the third construct of the study. Thus, each of the four scenarios were tested across gender lines, creating the 2x2x2 matrix. MANOVA was employed as the statistical method of analysis.

Measures

The two dependent variables of satisfaction and loyalty were each measured through 7-point, Likert type scales where “1” = “strongly disagree”, and “7” = “strongly agree”. Three items were adapted from Bowden-Everson, Dagger, & Elliott (2013) to measure satisfaction and an additional one item for loyalty from the same article. In addition, two items were adapted from Groth et al. (2009) for loyalty.

For the purposes of ensuring that participants interpreted the written scenarios as was intended, items concerning emotional labor and service quality were also included. All of the following were also measured through 7 point, Likert type scale where “1” = “strongly disagree”, and “7” = “strongly agree”. There were two items for service quality and six for emotional labor, all of which were adapted from Groth et al. (2009, p. 974).

Manipulation check

A pilot study was designed as a manipulation check to determine if there were significant differences in the scenarios. The sample was a convenience sample comprised of junior and senior level undergraduate hospitality students at a university in the western United States. A total of 168 surveys were distributed with 164 ($n = 164$) usable responses returned. The participants were randomly presented with one of the four written scenarios, with an equal number of each scenario being administered in each classroom.

Each scenario was manipulated with regard to its level of service quality, using SERVQUAL (Parasuraman et al., 1988) as the theoretical underpinning for what aspects of the service encounter should be changed. The following is a sample (not an exhaustive list) of some of those aspects and how they were presented in a high service quality scenario: the guest would have been seated in the specified amount of time, their order would have been taken in a timely fashion, all food would have been delivered hot and as ordered. In low service quality scenario those factors would have been presented as the “opposite”.

Each scenario was also manipulated with regard to the emotional labor and caring of the service provider. Emotional labor has often been conceptualized as the appearance of authenticity (Hennig-Thurau et al., 2006). As such, the scenarios were manipulated to provide actions that would reflect an authentic disposition or a lack there of. For example, in a deep acting scenario, the service provider not only shows care for the customer (in taking care of an allergy) but interjects themselves by offering additional information about local movies as well as asking after any time sensitivity on the part of the guests to get to their movie on time. Finally, the scenario also told the reader that the encounter with the service provider left them feeling a certain way about that individual: either that the service provider was faking or being sincere. As can be seen in the results that follow, these tactics were effective in producing the desired manipulation effect.

Data collection

For the full study, a market research firm (Qualtrics) was enlisted to recruit, disseminate, and collect the results of the electronic survey. There were only two requirements for participation: prospective samples must have been at least 18 years of age as well as having dined in a full-service restaurant in the previous 1 year. This research sought 400 usable responses to ensure adequate sampling with the given research design (Hair, Black, Babin, and Anderson (2013).

Once respondents qualified to participate, they were randomly assigned one of the four scenarios to read. Once they completed reading the scenario, they were presented with the questions of the survey. The sections included: (1) emotional labor, (2) service quality, (3) loyalty, (4) satisfaction, and (5) demographics.

Results

Manipulation check

The current scenarios were pretested for the purpose of manipulation check. Two independent-sample t-tests were performed to determine whether the manipulation of different categories among service quality and emotional labor was successful.

The results (see Table 1) indicated that participants assigned to the scenarios with high levels of service quality ($M = 5.386$, $SD = 1.599$) demonstrated significantly higher mean scores than participants assigned to scenarios with low levels of service quality ($M = 2.533$, $SD = 1.545$) with $t = 16.622$, $p < .001$ in the manipulation check.

Table 1. Manipulation check on differing levels of service quality and emotional labor.

	Quality scores <i>M</i> (<i>SD</i>)		<i>t</i>
	High level	Low level	
Service quality	5.386 (1.599)	2.533 (1.545)	16.622***
	Deep-acting	Surface-acting	<i>t</i>
Emotional labor	5.183 (1.177)	3.065 (0.853)	18.925***

*** $p < .001$

In terms of emotional labor, there was also a significant difference of mean scores in deep-acting ($M = 5.183$, $SD = 1.177$) and surface-acting ($M = 3.065$, $SD = 0.853$) with $t = 18.925$, $p < .001$. The results of the t -tests demonstrate a significant difference between the categories of each variable. Thus, the manipulation check for the scenarios was successful.

Main study

Among all the survey respondents, 186 (46.50%) were male and 214 (53.50%) were female. 57% of the sample had an associate degree or a bachelor's degree, and about 23% had a graduate degree. About two thirds of the respondents were younger than 40 years. In addition, approximately one third of subjects' household income was less than \$60,000 and about one fourth of respondents dined out less than four times in a month. A demographic profile is summarized in Table 2. The Cronbach's alpha scores for service quality ($\alpha = 0.97$), emotional labor (Surface-acting $\alpha = 0.91$; Deep-acting $\alpha = 0.85$), satisfaction ($\alpha = 0.97$) and loyalty ($\alpha = 0.98$) were all highly satisfactory.

To address the research questions and explore the relationships between satisfaction, loyalty, gender and the three independent variables, a 2x2x2 between-subject quasi-experimental design was employed. The data was analyzed accordingly, using three-way MANOVA (multivariate analysis of variance). Emotional labor (deep-acting vs. surface-acting), service quality (high vs. low), and gender (female vs. male) served as independent measures with two categories each. Customer satisfaction and loyalty were the dependent variables (Table 3). MANOVA was used because of the possibility of multicollinearity among the multiple dependent variables (Tabachnick & Fidell, 2001).

Wilk's Λ values were significant for main effects of emotional labor ($F = 86.51$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.31$), service quality ($F = 297.53$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.60$) and gender ($F = 4.80$, $p < .01$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$), and for the interaction effects of emotional labor*service quality ($F = 43.63$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.18$) and emotional labor*service quality*gender ($F = 5.68$, $p < .01$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$). Given these results, there was a minimum of one significant difference of satisfaction and loyalty among different levels of emotional labor, service quality, and gender. Each independent variable and their interactions on satisfaction and loyalty were further tested using ANOVA and t -tests.

The results of the ANOVAs indicated that both satisfaction ($F = 66.20$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.14$) and loyalty ($F = 64.48$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.14$) were significantly impacted by emotional labor. When emotional labor changed from deep-acting to surface-acting, customers' satisfaction mean score decreased from $M = 4.45$ to $M = 2.83$ (7 = most satisfied, 1 = least satisfied). The mean of loyalty also decreased from $M = 5.05$ to $M = 3.55$

Table 2. Demographic profile.

Characteristic	N = 400 (%)
Gender	
Male	186 (46.50)
Female	214 (53.50)
Age	
< 21	18 (4.50)
21 – 30	100 (25.00)
31 – 40	149 (37.25)
41 – 50	77 (19.25)
51 – 60	36 (9.00)
> 60	20 (5.00)
Annual household income	
< \$30,000	35 (8.80)
\$30,001 – \$60,000	97 (24.30)
\$60,001 – \$90,000	118 (29.50)
\$90,001 – \$120,000	58 (14.50)
> \$120,001	92 (23.00)
Education level	
High school/Trade school	80 (20.00)
Associate's degree	65 (16.25)
Bachelor	163 (40.75)
Master or above	92 (23.00)
Dining out frequency per month	
Less than 4 times	100 (25.00)
4–8 times	200 (50.00)
9–12 times	59 (14.75)
13–16 times	26 (6.50)
More than 16 times	17 (4.25)

Table 3. MANOVA results.

	Wilk's Λ	F	η^2
Emotional labor	0.69	86.51***	0.31
Service quality	0.40	297.53***	0.60
Gender	0.98	4.80**	0.02
Emotional labor*Service quality	0.82	43.63***	0.18
Emotional labor*Service quality*Gender	0.97	5.68**	0.03

Note. Both satisfaction and loyalty were measured on 7-point scales.

*** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, * $p < .05$

Table 4. ANOVA results for emotional labor, satisfaction, and loyalty.

	Emotional labor		F	η^2
	Deep-acting	Surface-acting		
Satisfaction	4.45	2.83	66.20***	0.14
Loyalty	5.05	3.55	64.48***	0.14

Note. Both satisfaction and loyalty were measured on 7-point scales.

*** $p < .001$

on 7-point-scale items (7 = most loyal, 1 = least loyal) (Table 4). Therefore, hypotheses 1 and 2 were supported.

Subsequently, ANOVA results also revealed that service quality significantly influenced both satisfaction ($F = 381.15$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.49$) and loyalty ($F = 344.56$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.46$). With a change in service quality from low to high, customers' satisfaction mean score increased from $M = 2.13$ to $M = 5.13$, and the mean score of loyalty also increased from $M = 2.93$ to $M = 5.66$ on 7-point scales (Table 5).

Table 5. ANOVA results for service quality, satisfaction, and loyalty.

	Service quality		<i>F</i>	η^2
	High	Low		
Satisfaction	5.13	2.13	381.15***	0.49
Loyalty	5.66	2.93	344.56***	0.46

Note. Both satisfaction and loyalty were measured on 7-point scales.

*** $p < .001$

Lastly, ANOVA results showed that gender only had a significant impact on loyalty ($F = 3.92$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = 0.01$) but not on satisfaction ($F = 1.06$, $p = .30$, $\eta^2 = 0.003$). Females had a significantly higher mean score on loyalty ($M = 4.48$) than males ($M = 4.09$), but there was no significant difference between males and females on satisfaction (Table 6).

In terms of interaction effects, the interactions between emotional labor and service quality for satisfaction ($F = 40.67$, $p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.09$) were shown to be significant, but not for loyalty ($F = 1.39$, $p = .24$, $\eta^2 = 0.003$). The interactions between emotional labor and gender for satisfaction ($F = 4.46$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = 0.01$) and for loyalty ($F = 6.07$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = 0.001$) were significant. The interactions between service quality and gender for satisfaction ($F = 0.57$, $p = .45$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$) and for loyalty ($F = 0.52$, $p = .47$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$) were not significant. Furthermore, the three-way interactions between emotional labor, service quality, and gender for satisfaction ($F = 0.007$, $p = .94$, $\eta^2 = 0.00$) and for loyalty ($F = 3.46$, $p = .06$, $\eta^2 = 0.01$) were not significant. Therefore, there was not find adequate support for hypotheses 3 and 4.

When the emotional labor variable was deep-acting, the high level of service quality created drastically higher satisfaction compared to a low level of service quality ($M_{high-service} = 6.35$, $M_{low-service} = 2.55$). Similarly, when the emotional labor was surface-acting, a high level of service quality created significantly higher satisfaction compared to a low-level service quality ($M_{high-service} = 3.93$, $M_{low-service} = 1.71$) (Table 7). The simple effects between the two different levels of service quality on satisfaction for both deep-acting and surface-acting were tested using independent samples t-tests. The results indicated that when emotional labor was represented through deep-acting, there was a significant difference between high and low levels of service quality ($t = 21.74$, $p < .001$). Likewise, when the emotional labor was represented through surface-acting, a significant difference between high and low levels of service quality was observed again ($t = 12.58$, $p < .001$).

When the service quality variable was high, the provision of deep-acting created drastically higher satisfaction compared to a surface-acting ($M_{deep-acting} = 6.35$, $M_{surface-acting} = 3.93$). Similarly, when service quality was low, the provision of deep-acting created drastically higher satisfaction compared to a surface-acting ($M_{deep-acting} = 2.55$, $M_{surface-acting} = 1.06$) (Table 7). The simple effects between the two strategies for emotional labor (deep-acting and surface-acting) on satisfaction for both low service quality and high

Table 6. Results of ANOVA tests for gender.

	Gender		<i>F</i>	η^2
	Female	Male		
Satisfaction	3.74	3.52	1.06	0.003
Loyalty	4.48	4.09	3.92*	0.01

Note. Both satisfaction and loyalty were measured on 7-point scales.

* $p < .05$

Table 7. Emotional labor $\times$ service quality interaction on satisfaction.

		Service quality		<i>t</i>
		High	Low	
Satisfaction	Deep-acting	6.35	2.55	21.74***
	Surface-acting	3.93	1.71	12.58***

		Emotional Labor		<i>t</i>
		Deep-acting	Surface-acting	
Satisfaction	High	6.35	3.93	14.68***
	Low	2.55	1.71	4.54***

Note. Service quality and emotional labor were measured on a 7-point Likert scale. Service quality 1 = low, 7 = high; Emotional labor 1 = surface acting, 7 = deep acting. *** $p < .001$.

service quality were tested using independent samples *t*-tests. The results indicated that when service quality was high, there was a significant difference between deep-acting and surface-acting ($t = 14.68$, $p < .001$). Likewise, when service quality was low, there was a significant difference between deep-acting and surface-acting ($t = 4.54$, $p < .001$).

When the emotional labor variable was deep-acting, females demonstrated a higher degree of satisfaction than males ($M_{females} = 4.74$, $M_{males} = 4.11$). However, when the emotional labor was surface-acting, males demonstrated a higher degree of satisfaction than females ($M_{females} = 2.73$, $M_{males} = 2.94$) (Table 8). The simple effects between the two genders on satisfaction for both deep-acting and surface-acting were tested using independent samples *t*-tests. The results indicated that when emotional labor was represented through deep-acting, there was a significant difference in satisfaction scores between females and males ($t = 1.96$, $p < .05$). However, when emotional labor was represented through surface-acting, no significant difference in satisfaction scores between females and males was observed ($t = -0.09$, $p = .37$). These findings supported hypothesis 5.

When the emotional labor variable was deep-acting, females demonstrated a higher degree of loyalty than males ($M_{females} = 5.43$, $M_{males} = 4.59$). However, when the emotional labor was surface-acting, males demonstrated a higher degree of loyalty than females ($M_{females} = 3.52$, $M_{males} = 3.59$) (Table 9). The simple effects between the two genders on satisfaction for both deep-acting and surface-acting were tested using independent samples *t*-tests. The results indicated that when emotional labor was represented through deep-acting, there was a significant difference in loyalty scores between females

Table 8. Emotional labor $\times$ gender on satisfaction.

		Gender		<i>t</i>
		Female	Male	
Satisfaction	Deep-acting	4.74	4.11	1.96*
	Surface-acting	2.73	2.94	-0.90

* $p < .05$

Table 9. Emotional labor $\times$ gender on loyalty.

		Gender		<i>t</i>
		Female	Male	
Loyalty	Deep-acting	5.43	4.59	3.14**
	Surface-acting	3.52	3.59	0.29

** $p < .01$

and males ($t = 3.14$, $p < .01$). However, when emotional labor was represented through surface-acting, no significant difference in loyalty scores between females and males was observed ($t = -0.29$, $p = .776$). Thus, hypothesis 6 was supported.

Discussion

The human condition inherently necessitates that on any given day in the service industry, a human server may or may not be checking his or her emotions at the door before providing service. Because people are a pivotal part of the service delivery process in most restaurant settings, service is invariably inconsistent. Therefore, the ways in which customers evaluate the service encounter and the sincerity of the server during the provision of service are important to consider. The aim of this study was to determine the impact of gender on satisfaction and loyalty while service and emotional display conditions were manipulated. This topic is of importance as there is conflicting evidence in the literature that suggests gender does (Iacobucci & Ostrom, 1993; Ma et al., 2014; Yelkur & Chakrabarty, 2006) and does not influence satisfaction and loyalty (Mattila, 2000).

Theoretical implications

First, it was found that the deep-acting emotional labor strategy yielded statistically greater satisfaction than did surface-acting. The same held true for emotional labor deep-acting versus surface-acting on loyalty. These results support the findings of previous studies (Barger & Grandey, 2006; Groth et al., 2013; Hennig-Thurau et al., 2006; Mattila & Enz, 2002), but builds on them as this study demonstrates the merits of deep-acting on the customer, not simply the service provider. Additionally, as service quality increased, so did satisfaction and loyalty. These results are not surprising as myriad previous studies on service quality and the service profit chain have demonstrated that as service quality improves, so too does customer satisfaction and loyalty (e.g. Cronin & Taylor, 1992; Groth et al., 2009; Ladhari et al., 2008; Moreo et al., 2018).

While no significant three-way interaction was detected, this research still provides useful, theoretical advancement in the subsequent findings related to gender, emotional labor, and service quality on loyalty and satisfaction. For example, this research demonstrated that when the gender of the customer was female, deep-acting produced a significantly higher level of loyalty, whereas there was not a statistically significant difference among male clientele on loyalty when they experienced deep-acting versus surface-acting. This aligns with previous research that demonstrated that female customers are more concerned with the interpersonal attitudinal attributes of the service encounter in addition to core performance (Anderson et al., 2008), whereas their male counterparts were more focused on the core performance (Iacobucci & Ostrom, 1993). If the service encounter appears genuine (deep acting), female clientele are more likely to remain loyal to the organization where men may still prefer to switch providers. This is supported by previous literature discussing the tendency for females to be more interdependent where males tend to be more independent (Cross & Madson, 1997; Melnyk et al., 2009).

While there was a statistically significant impact of deep-acting versus surface-acting on satisfaction, contrary to the assumptions of the researchers, there was no difference across genders on their satisfaction with varying levels of service quality. This finding differs from the assertions of previous scholars who have demonstrated differences in satisfaction on evaluations of service in hospitality organizations, with female clientele typically being higher (Ramanathan et al., 2016) and valuing interpersonal attributes more than men (Anderson et al., 2008). However, it is in agreement with the findings of Mattila (2000) who observed no statistical difference between males and females on satisfaction in a service setting. Ultimately, this suggests that service quality is important for satisfaction no matter which gender is being served.

Managerial implications

For managers, there are practical implications. In a vacuum, the ideal would be to ensure consistent levels of service quality and authenticity by individual service providers from encounter to encounter, as well consistency between service providers. This would ensure that all customers received high quality service with the desired level of authenticity at all times. Since this study has shown that deep acting will result in higher satisfaction versus shallow acting, regardless of the type of service quality, it behooves a manager or company to provide some deep acting training as well as incentives and encouragement to deep act to the customers. This may be achieved by helping the servers to align their internal feeling to their outward demeanor. If service with a smile is an expectation, then method acting techniques may be employed to produce positive emotions inside. In this way, the internalized emotions will help support the external portrayal.

However, since service providers understand that not all clients desire the same service, and for practical purposes, they may not be able to always be consistent in their emotional labor strategies, understanding how male and female clientele respond to differing levels of service and authenticity is pivotal for ensuring satisfaction, positive word of mouth and revisit intention. If the clientele of a restaurant or if a specific table is largely female, it would behoove management to stress the importance of being genuine in all aspects of service as this is likely to have a positive impact on whether or not positive word of mouth and revisit intention is to occur. Therefore, identifying the way in which the company wishes for the servers to represent themselves and clearly delineating those attributes in a service provider handbook is strongly advised. Additionally, when servers are recognized by clientele for these efforts via positive word of mouth to management or on social media platforms, it is recommended that the service provider be praised and rewarded to further encourage deep acting in the restaurant.

Ultimately, this study has demonstrated that female clientele invests more in the emotions and attitudes of the servers and that this may impact their satisfaction and loyalty. Understanding this behavior can help servers to tailor their actions to provide the greatest impressions on the clientele. The salience of emotional labor was shown to be pivotal for generating higher levels of satisfaction and loyalty. Theoretically, the implication is that deep acting may increase satisfaction and loyalty and compensate for low service quality. Additionally, deep acting is even stronger for repeat visit intention and positive word of mouth among female than among male clientele.

Limitations and conclusion

No study is without limitation. Because the respondents were gathered from a professional survey company, they may not be representative of the general dining public. Therefore, generalizability cannot be guaranteed. Additionally, this study was conducted employing a between subject quasi-experimental design with written scenarios. These hypothetical written scenarios may have been too removed from reality to elicit genuine feelings of satisfaction or loyalty from the participants. Although the manipulation checks conducted indicated the scenarios were sufficiently different, this could have been more of a cerebral reaction instead of an emotional one. Additionally, given that the server's gender was not manipulated in this study, the authors are not able to assess whether the gender effects that are observed in this study are predicated on the gender of the server. Future research could investigate if server gender and customer gender influence decisions regarding service quality, loyalty, and satisfaction (Mattila et al., 2003). Future research could conduct the experiment in a restaurant setting and enlist the help of diners in real time using a tablet with the scenarios provided. This would assist with generalizability as well as provide a more genuine setting for the study.

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